

Employer Recognition of Job Readiness in New Americans:

A Case Study

Doug Belshaw & Julie Keane

ePIC 2024, Paris

Slides: bit.ly/epic-new-americans



We'll Untangle Your Organisational Spaghetti

We're a not-for-profit worker co-op of strategists, innovators, and facilitators.

We design and deliver strategies and tactics to untangle your organisational spaghetti by working hand-in-hand with you and your team, helping everyone learn how and where to intervene in complex systems.

<https://weareopen.coop>



Participate is your *all-in-one* social learning solution.

Empowering community-based learning with Communities of Practice, Professional Learning Communities, Special Interest Groups, Employee Resource Groups, and Centers of Excellence.

 TRY FOR FREE NOW

<https://participate.com>

Some context



What we do



U.S. program offerings

The International Rescue Committee is one of the leading providers of services for refugees, asylees and asylum seekers, victims of trafficking and other vulnerable immigrants in the United States. Across the country, each year, the IRC serves over 35,000 individuals with an array of services aimed at helping them to survive, reclaim control of their future and strengthen their communities.

We measure our progress on this mission by assessing improvements in the long-term outcomes of the women, men, girls and boys that we serve—their health, safety, education, economic wellbeing, and empowerment. We want to achieve our goal while we deliver the greatest impact for the most people at the lowest cost, and so are committed to constantly strengthening the effectiveness of our programs, responsiveness to clients and communities, and to reach more people with timely evidence-based assistance.

Across our [U.S. offices](#), the IRC offers the following programs:

- [Resettlement](#)
- [Economic empowerment](#)

<https://rescue.org>

[Home](#) / [About Jobs for the Future](#) /

About Jobs for the Future

Our Vision

We envision a society where equitable economic advancement is attainable by all.

[Join us →](#)

Who We Are

Jobs for the Future (JFF) is a national nonprofit that drives transformation of the U.S. education and workforce systems to

<https://jff.org>

“

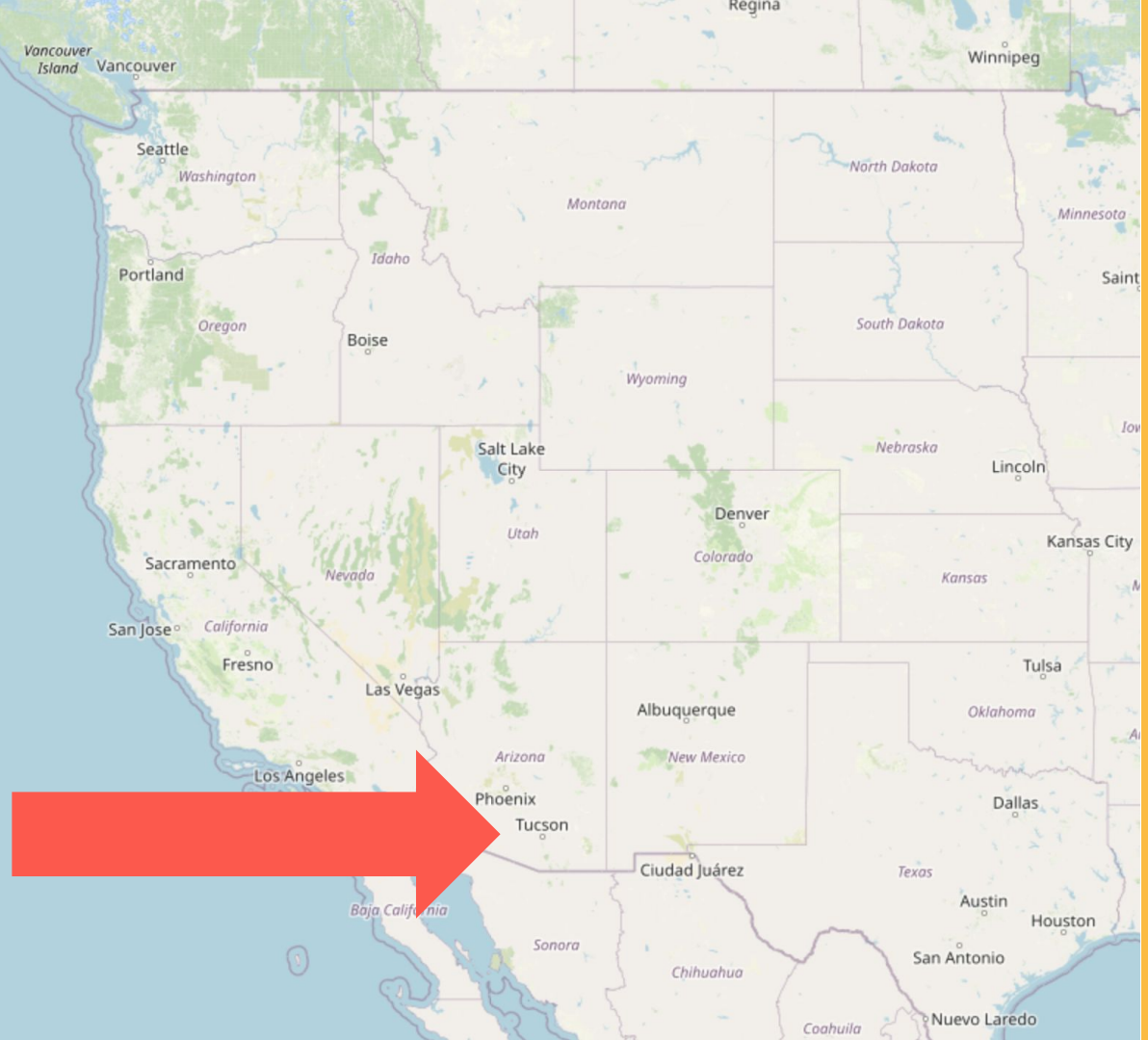
We want to understand what works, but also what doesn't work... if this is not meaningful to them or not meaningful to employers, we just want to understand why and how we can design something that is worthwhile and a value add moving forward.



(Paige Korbakes, Director, JFF)

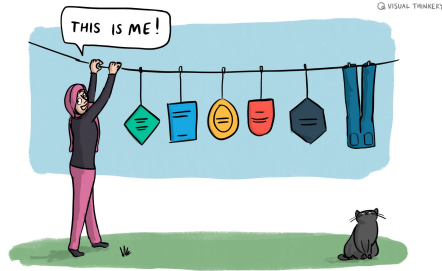
”

For operational
and logistics
reasons, the
project was
limited to the
IRC office in
Tucson, Arizona



Insights into the International Rescue Committee's Job Readiness Training Credential

Executive Summary



The **International Rescue Committee (IRC)** and **Jobs for the Future (JFF)** initiated a pilot program around the use of **Verifiable Credentials (VCs)** to connect **New Americans** (i.e. immigrants and refugees to the USA) with **employers**.

Participate was the technology partner using Open Badges v3, with support from **MIT's Digital Credentials Consortium**.

We Are Open Co-op (WAO) was engaged to collect, analyse, and evaluate the data presented in this summary.

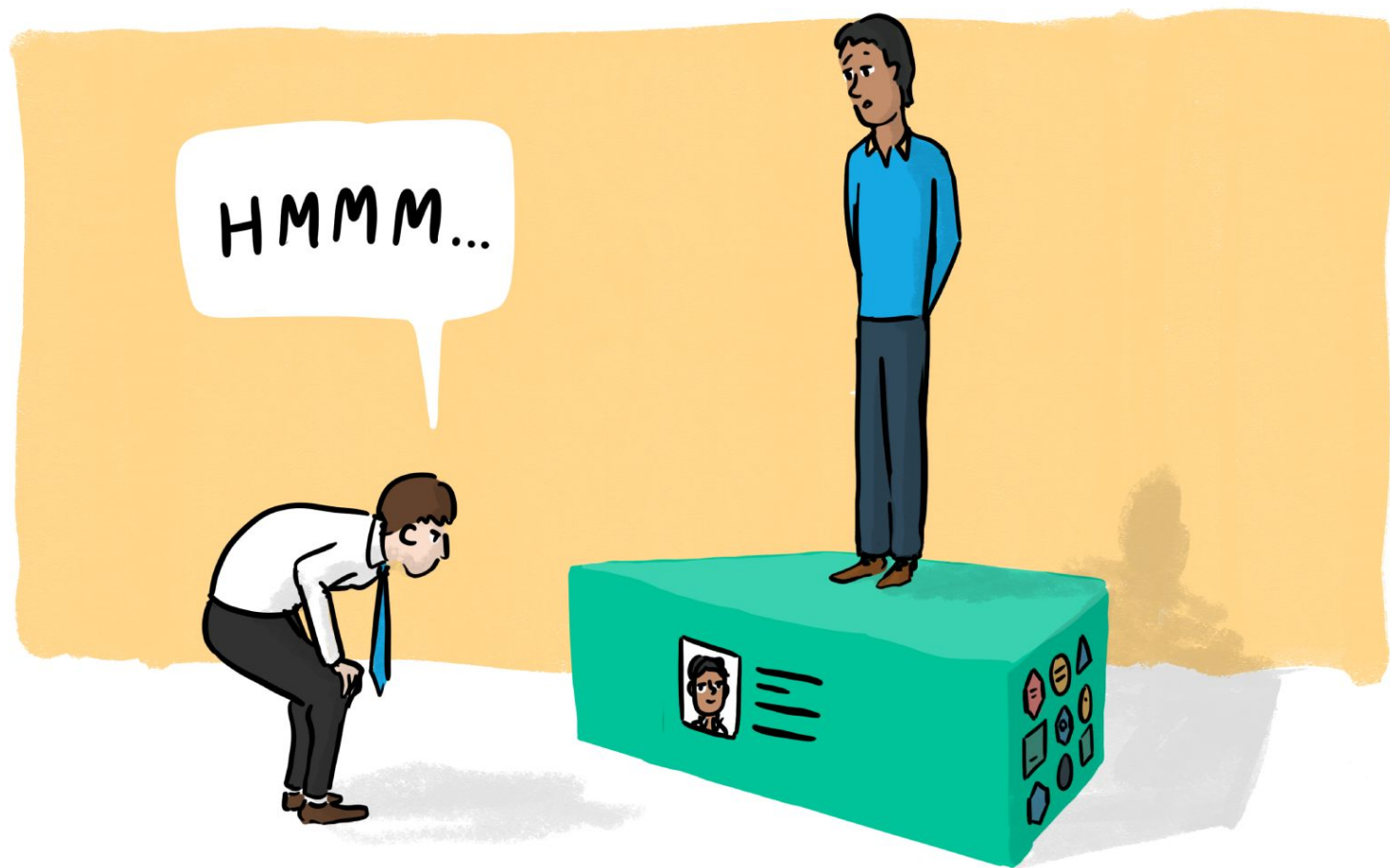


All images used under a
Creative Commons Licence.

HOW DO WE CURRENTLY EVALUATE

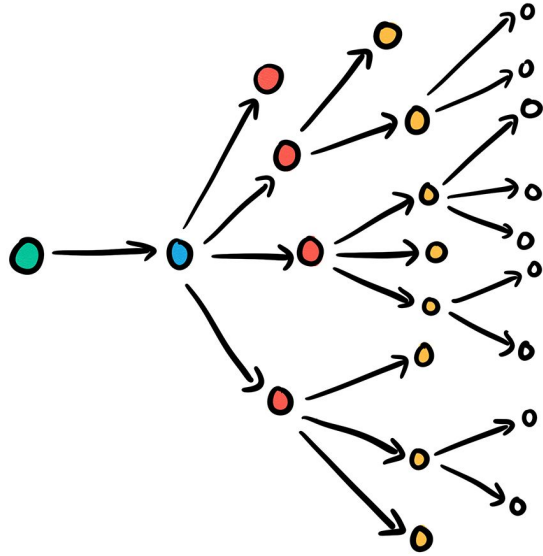


A CANDIDATE'S SKILLS?



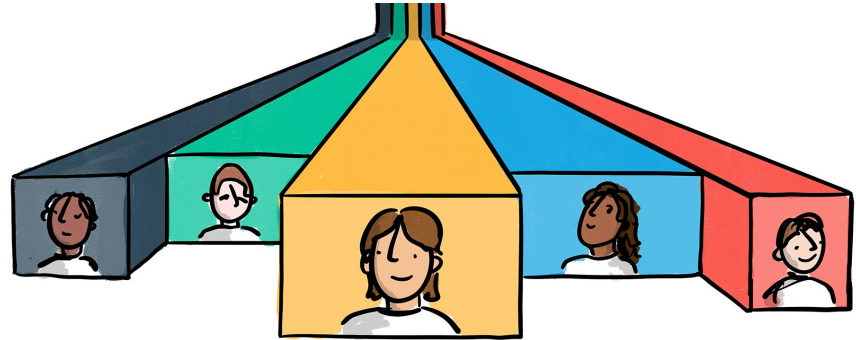
Approach

Approaches



Stakeholder surveys

(quantitative data)



User Research interviews

(qualitative data)

“

Success has kind of evolved as we've pivoted...
creating awareness and building excitement around
what this technology could be and could do.

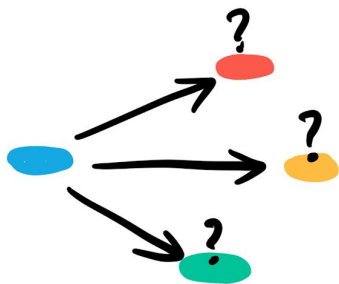


(Ikeia Miller, Senior Program Manager, JFF)

”

Numbers

	IRC Clients	IRC/JFF Staff	Employer Partners	Other
Surveys	8	6	13	—
Interviews	6	9	2	2

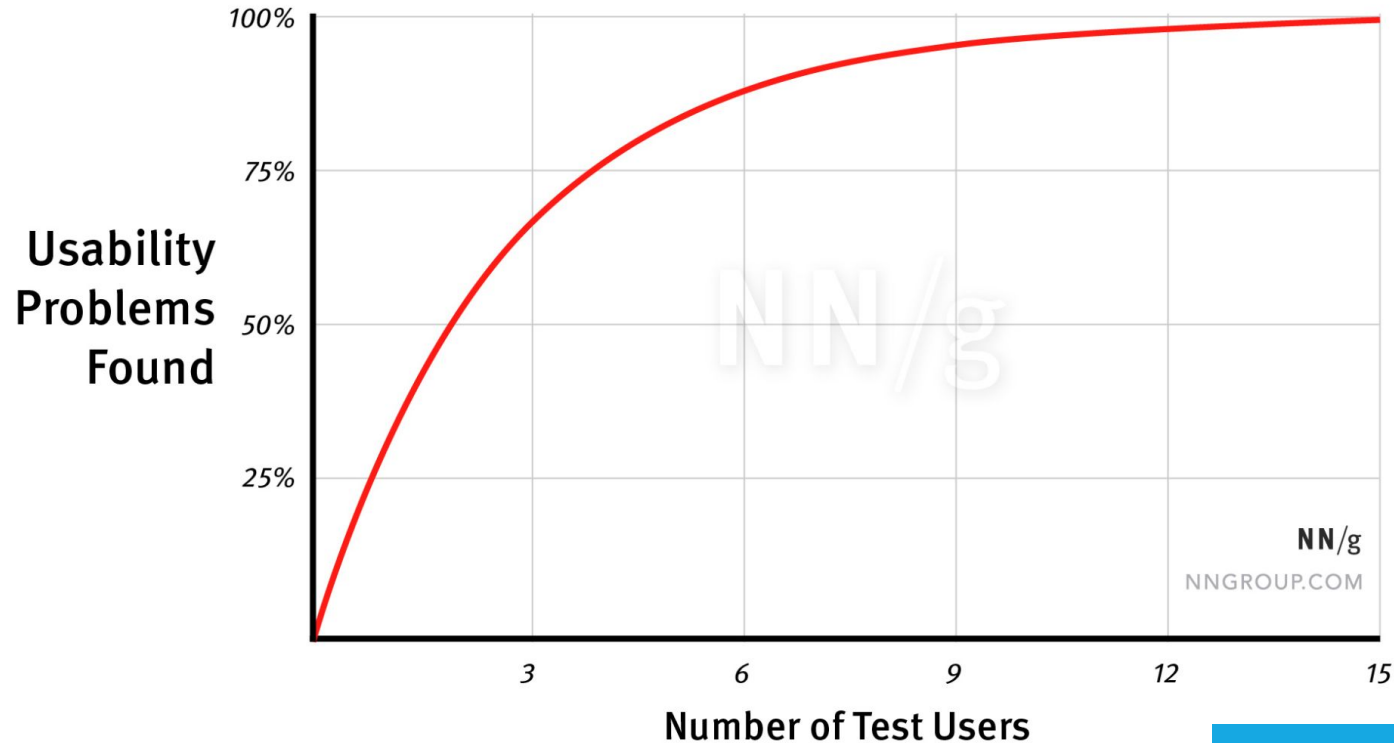


EXPLORATORY



VALIDATING

5 Users: The Optimal Sample Size for Qualitative Usability Studies



<https://bit.ly/3Yjcciw>



Job Readiness Training for New Americans

Issuer



International Rescue
Committee

<https://www.rescue.org/>

Issuance Date

9 Jul 2024

Description

The recipient of this credential has been trained in best practices in workplace culture in the U.S. including communication and navigating common human resources systems, searching and applying for jobs including developing interview skills, and best practices in starting a job including completing onboarding procedures and understanding workplace safety and rights. The recipient has practiced these skills through vocabulary activities, speaking and communication practice activities, role play activities, resume writing and job search activities, and interview practice and training. The recipient has demonstrated these competencies through oral and written comprehension assessments, a mock interview assessment, a job application practical examination, and an on-the-job role play assessment. Job Readiness Training for New Americans is a 6-module curriculum delivered by trained IRC instructors and is designed to ensure that individuals have a strong foundation of work skills that can reinforce job success and retention. Competencies & Skills Attained: Proficient Understanding of US Work Culture & Professional Attire, Effective Communication Skills, Demonstrated Reliability, Demonstrated Punctuality & Time Management Skills in the Workplace, Adaptive Attitude and Receptive to Feedback, and Team Collaboration

Criteria

Successful completion of this certification requires passing of a comprehensive assessment of job readiness skills by qualified IRC staff. Assessment mechanisms for each module are outlines above. Individuals are scored by two IRC staff members on a detailed rubric with a 0-3 scale for each piece of the assessment. Recipients of this certificate have scored an overall 2 or higher, reflecting successful demonstration of requisite skills.



Credential Verified

Last Checked: 17 Sept 2024



Run Verification

Issuer

- ✓ Has been issued by a registered institution:
 - DCC Pilot Registry

Credential

- ✓ Has a valid digital signature
- ✓ Has not expired
- ✓ Has not been revoked by issuer

Findings



“

If someone's going to skim this thing in like 60 seconds tops, how can we make it super clear what the most important points are? Or can we use bold? Can we use bullet points? Can we like, change the visual format so that it's like a real quick, they skim it and they see exactly what they need?

(IRC Staff)

”



Suggestions

1. Recipient

Clarification: make it clear *who* earned the credential.

2. Enhanced

Presentation: use text formatting to highlight key skills and make it more digestible to employers.

3. Broader Skill

Recognition: formal recognition could help in presenting the broad range of New Americans' skills to prospective employers.

The screenshot shows a digital credential interface. Red arrows and numbers highlight areas for improvement:

- Arrow 1:** Points to the 'Issued To:' field, which contains '[NAME OF IRC CLIENT]'. This area needs clarification on the recipient.
- Arrow 2:** Points to the 'Description' section, which lists skills like 'Accessing the US Job Market' and 'Preparing for Employment'. This area needs enhanced presentation for better readability.
- Arrow 3:** Points to the 'Skill Development Practice' section, which describes the training activities. This area needs broader skill recognition.

Issued To:
[NAME OF IRC CLIENT]

Description
The earner of this credential has successfully completed the IRC Job Readiness Training (JRT) for New Americans. JRT is a 6-module curriculum delivered by IRC to ensure that New Americans have work skills that reinforce job success. The programme covers:

- **Accessing the US Job Market**
 - Job Search & Resume Development
 - Interview Skills
 - Workplace Safety and Rights
- **Preparing for Employment**
 - Onboarding & Reliability
 - Time Management & Adaptability
 - Receptive to Feedback
- **US Workplace Culture**
 - Communication & Appearance
 - HR Systems & Punctuality
 - Team Collaboration

Skill Development Practice
The earner has developed skills through vocabulary activities, speaking practice, role play, resume writing, job search tasks, and interview training. Competencies were demonstrated via comprehension assessments, a mock interview, a job application exam, and an on-the-job role play assessment.

Scoring
Successful completion of this certification requires passing of a comprehensive assessment of job readiness skills by qualified IRC staff. Individuals are scored by two IRC staff members on a detailed rubric with a 0-3 scale for each piece of the assessment. Recipients of this certificate have scored an overall 2 or higher, reflecting successful demonstration of requisite skills.

✓ Credential Verified
Last Checked: 3 Sept 2024

Run Verification

Issuer

- ✓ Has been issued by a registered institution:
 - DCC Pilot Registry

Credential

- ✓ Has a valid digital signature
- ✓ Has not expired
- ✓ Has not been revoked by issuer

Stakeholder Perceptions

- **Employers** want to be able to quickly assess a candidate's qualifications
- **IRC Staff** want to improve the JRT and are enthusiastic about the possibility of using digital credentials
- **New Americans** are eager to find ways to showcase their skills, but need support in using digital credentials and associated technologies.

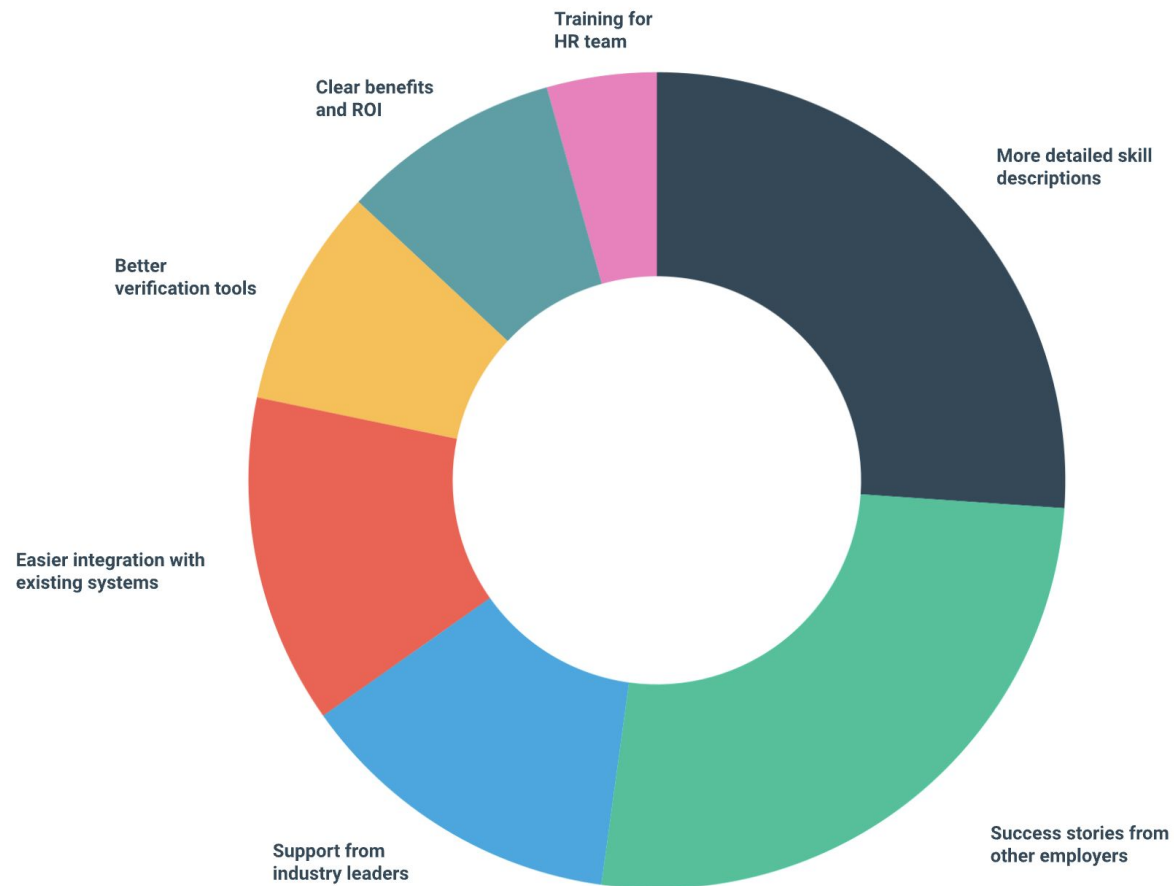
Employers

...are interested in:

- Understanding **specific skills** that New Americans could demonstrate (e.g. technical, IT, or carpentry skills)
- Nuance around an earner's **strengths** and **weaknesses**, including how they compared to other New Americans who had completed JRT.
- Knowing more about the **organization** issuing the credential (the IRC).
- **Language** support that the candidate might need in the workplace.
- Links to **evidence** backing up the claims made in the credential.



What would make you MORE LIKELY to accept this credential as part of your hiring process?



“

We have to evaluate everything. It would be incredibly helpful to know what country someone is from, what language they use. It can take up to an hour to do that, as opposed to having that information at our fingertips.

”



(Employer Partner)

IRC Staff

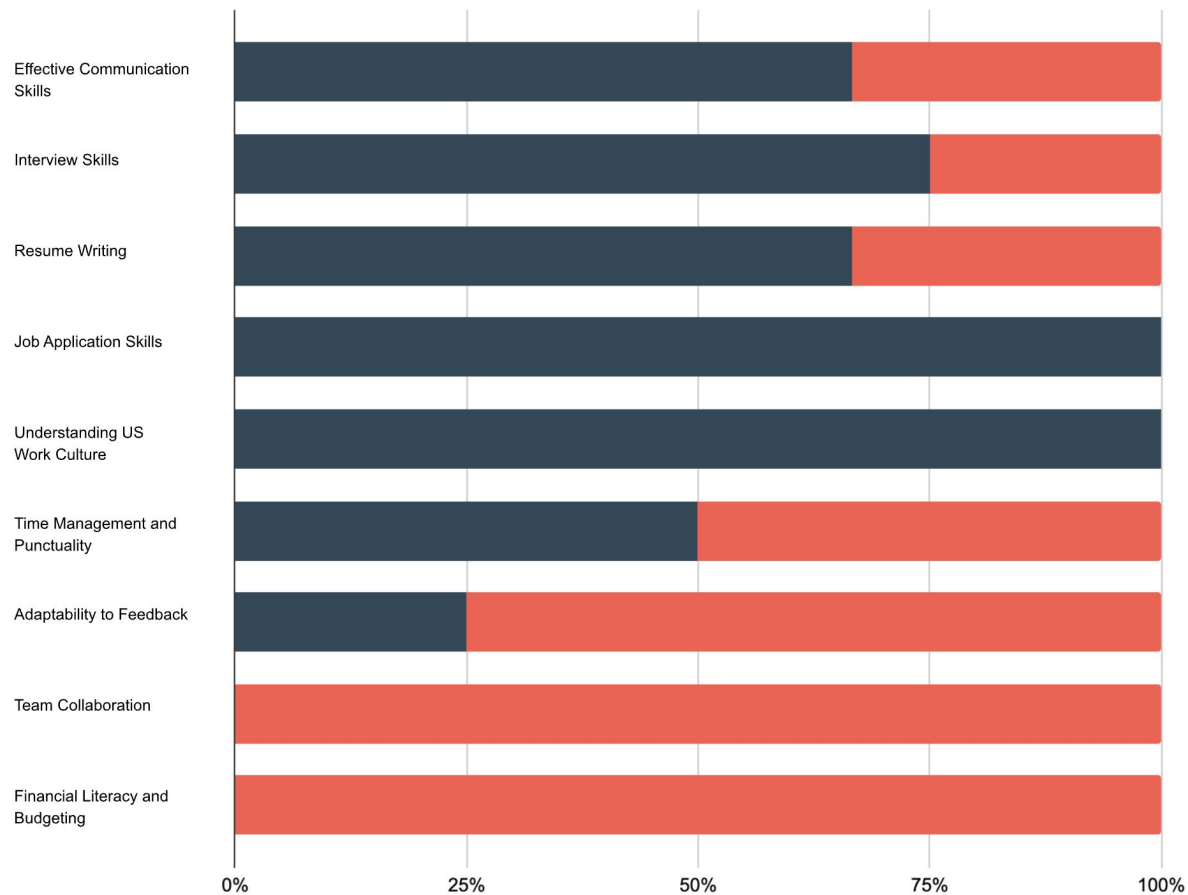
...told us that they are:

- **Confident** in using and explaining the credential
- **Optimistic** about the possibility that the new credential could help reduce the time needed for matching clients with employers.
- **Positive** about the ways in which the credential reflected the skills and knowledge acquired through the curriculum

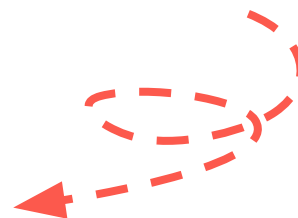


How effectively key skills or knowledge areas are represented

■ Communicated effectively ■ Not well represented



The JRT doesn't really cover this in much depth



“

I think it shows [employers] something much more real and visible that makes it seem... more formalized, more standardized, more dependable.



(Kevin Davis, Sr. Program Officer, Workforce, IRC)

”

New Americans

...indicated to us that they are:

- **Unsure** whether or not they have received a credential.
- **Grateful** to IRC Staff for their help in helping them become established in the USA.
- **Unused** to being asked what they are good at, over and above the requirements of a particular course.

Important note: we are aware of the power dynamics at play in asking New Americans to participate in an interview. We offered compensation to participants, but language barriers, the legal and/or socio-economic status of the participants, and their gratitude to the IRC may bias them towards positivity in the interview process.



IT'S IN MY
WALLET...

...I MEAN
MY PHONE...

... IT JUST
WORKS!



“

Clients did not relate to the word ‘credential’ - even in their own language. So, I had to use the words ‘app’ or ‘JRT certificate’ instead. Clients may call it something else once we add more to the wallet, to differentiate between them.



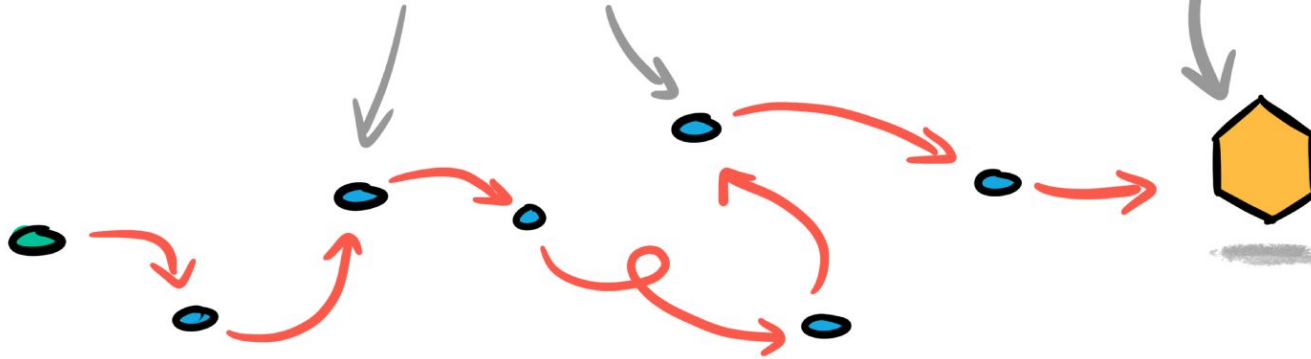
(Sheenice Hernandez, RSS Employment Specialist, IRC)

”

Recommendations

CREDENTIALS
WHICH ARE PART
OF THE JOURNEY

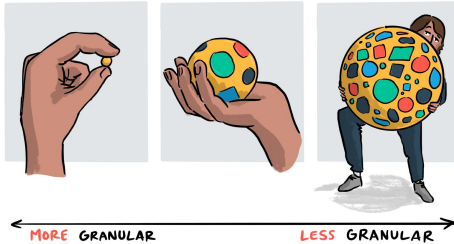
CREDENTIALS
TO RECOGNISE
THE END OF THE JOURNEY



3 Types of Visibility

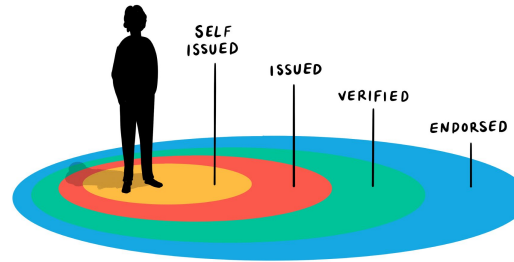
1 Granularity in the JRT Credentials

HOW BIG SHOULD A CREDENTIAL BE?



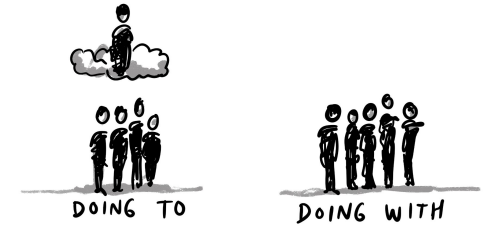
- More visibility of what happens in the JRT program
- Opportunity for collaborations including multi-lingual support
- Promote true inclusivity

2 Diversity in IRC Credentials



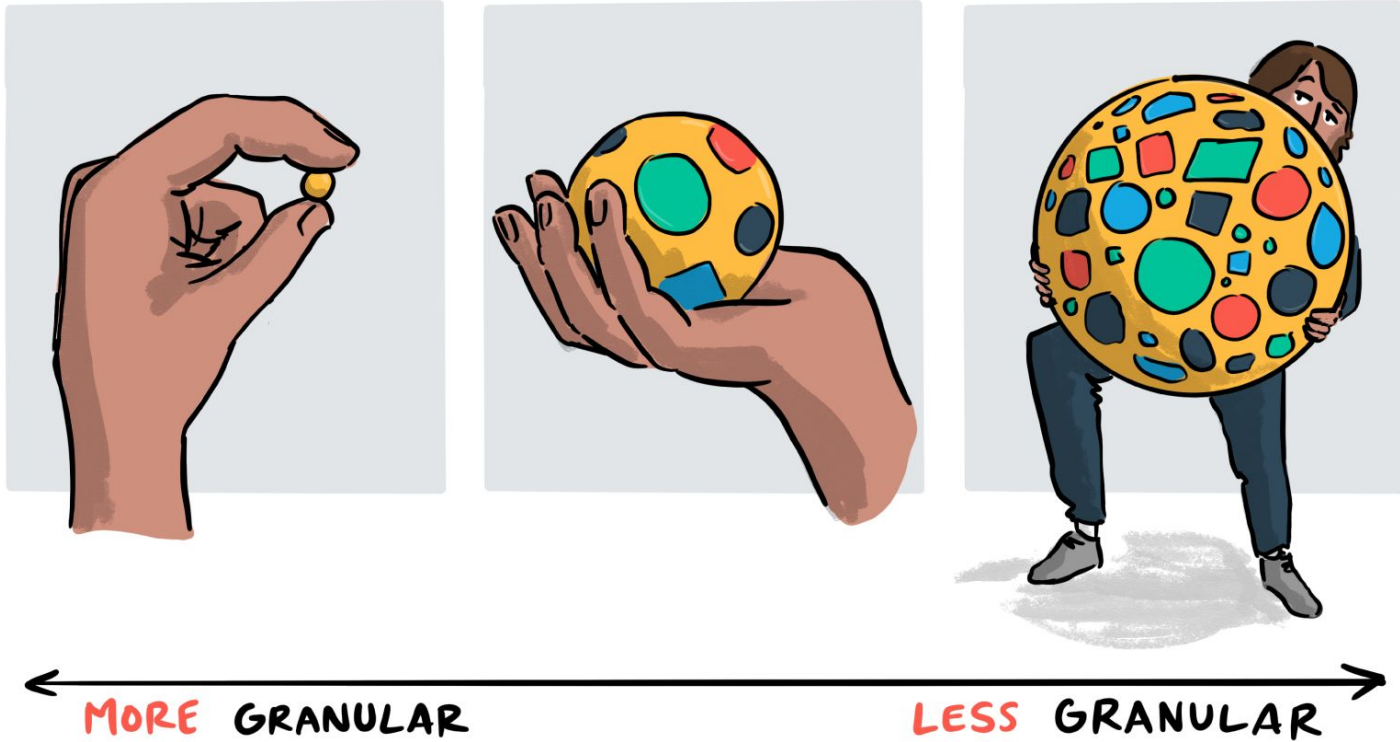
- Detail IRC program offerings and support
- Facilitate social networks and support circles for New Americans
- Help illuminate the diversity of New Americans through self and peer-identification

3 Locality of IRC Credentials



- Help hyper-local partnerships and collaborations flourish
- Build more partnerships, including with educational providers
- Promote visibility amongst employers

HOW BIG SHOULD A CREDENTIAL BE?



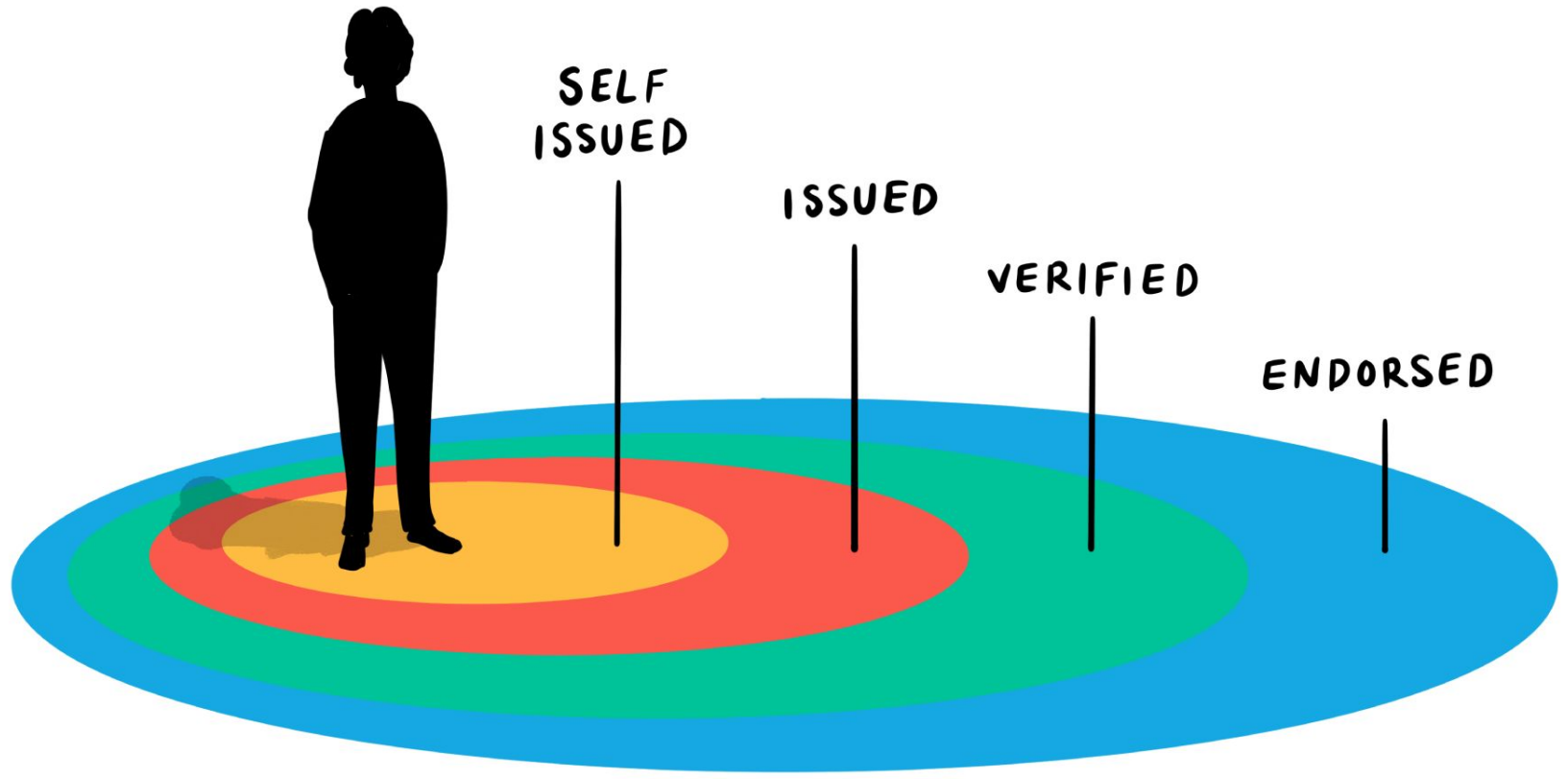
“

Is this a one day boot camp? Is this a six week program? [...] I don't think any of our programs are a one day boot camp... they're multi-week programs that require a significant, meaningful investment of time [so] I think an employer would like to see that.

(IRC Staff)

”





“

Those who already know about the existence of this diploma should talk more around them so that many people know that it is a plus in the world of employment.

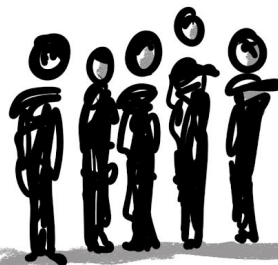
”



(New American interviewee)



DOING TO



DOING WITH

WAO

“

No matter what we change about the credential design... if people don't know about it, it does nothing for anyone, including the user.



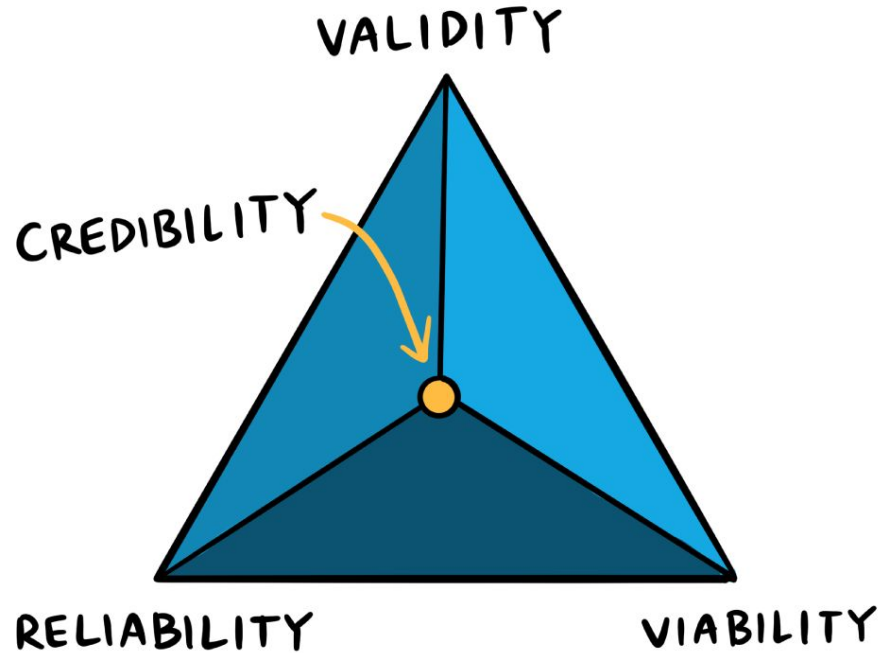
(Meena Naik, Director, Skills First Design, JFFLabs)

”

BLOOP! - IT JUST WORKS.



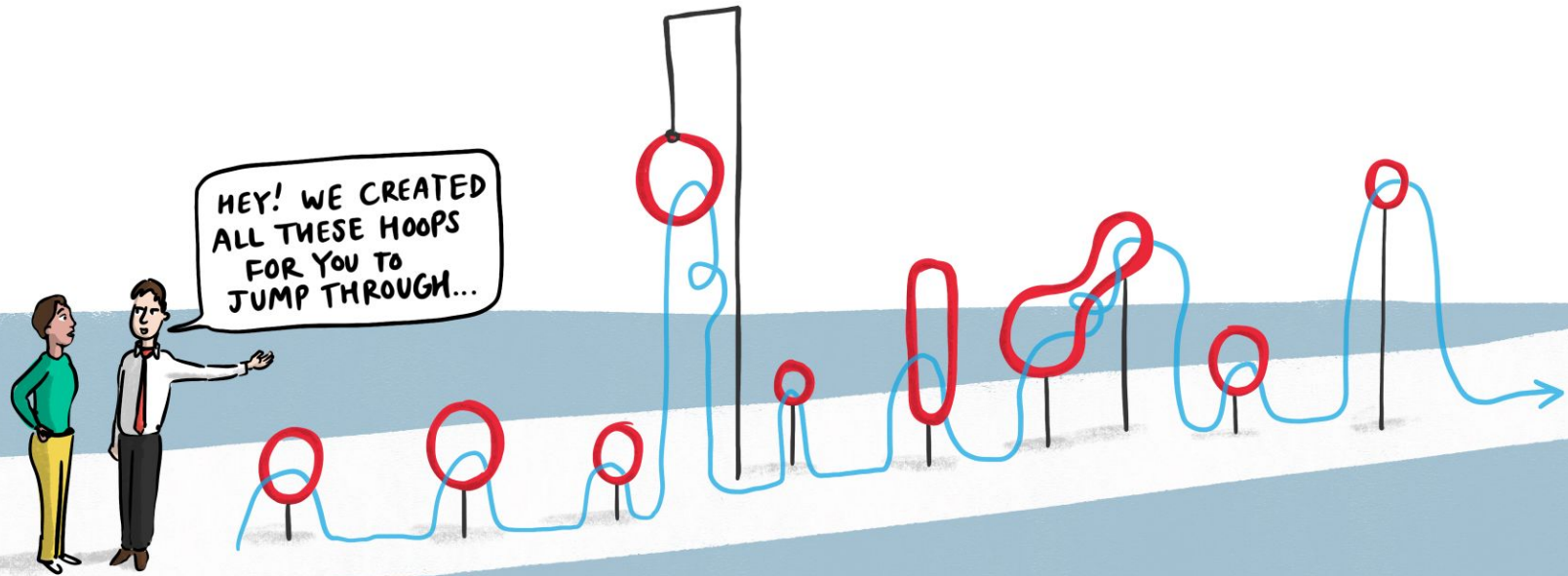
CREDIBILITY OF CREDENTIALS



I AM MORE THAN JUST MY RESUMÉ



Some Open Recognition-related takeaways



“

It is very easy to use... for people like me. I don't have much knowledge of things here.

(New American interviewee)

”





“

Are we setting up an expectation for employers that without this, people won't be reliable or won't know how to communicate or won't be punctual?



(Betsy Fisher, U.S. Director, Talent Beyond Boundaries)

”

LOOK!
I HAVE A
PUNCTUALITY
CREDENTIAL!

**NOT HAVING A PUNCTUALITY
CREDENTIAL DOESN'T MEAN
WE'RE **NOT** PUNCTUAL!**



RECOGNISING THE RIGHTS OF



INDIVIDUALS,



COMMUNITIES

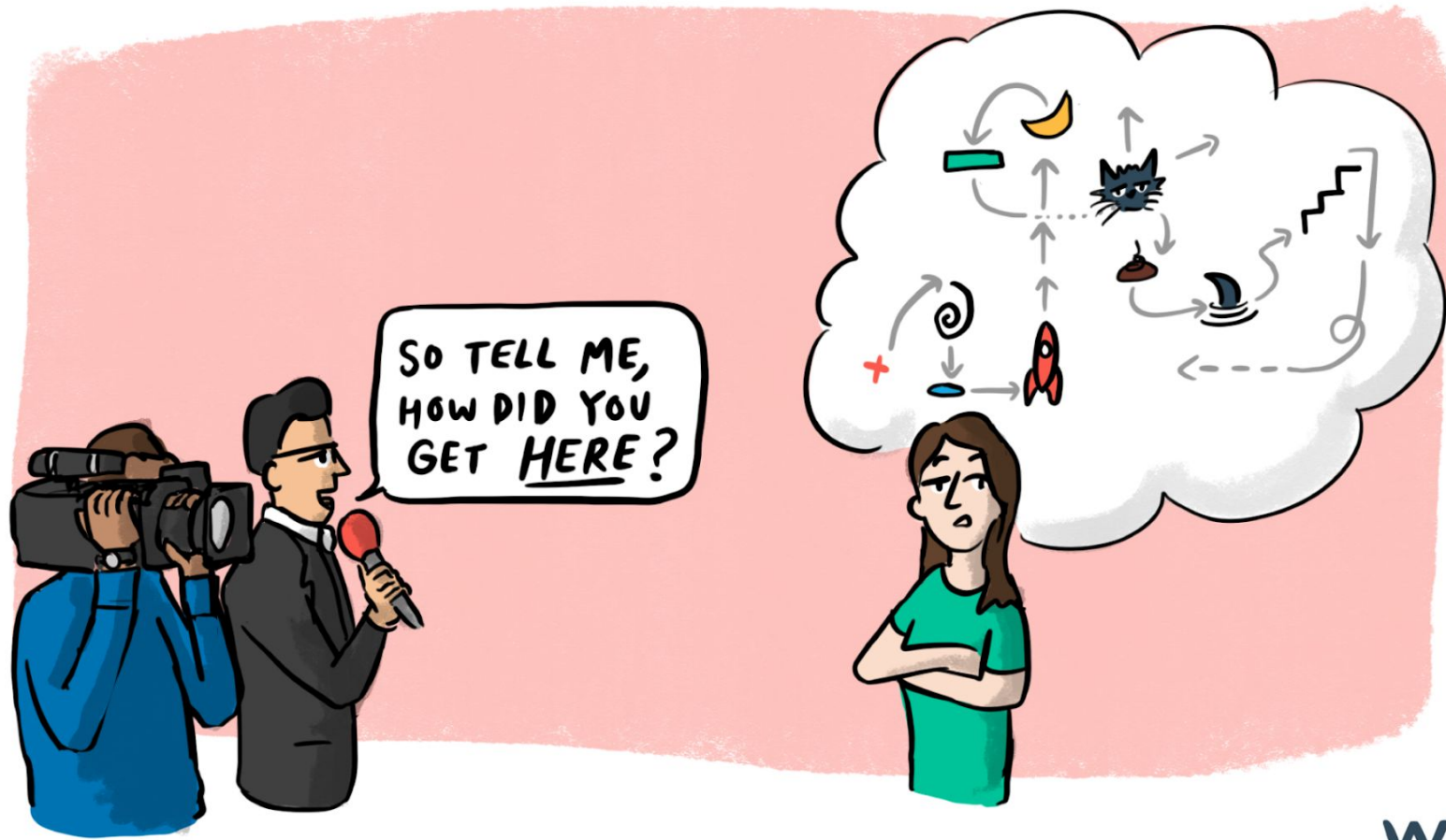


&

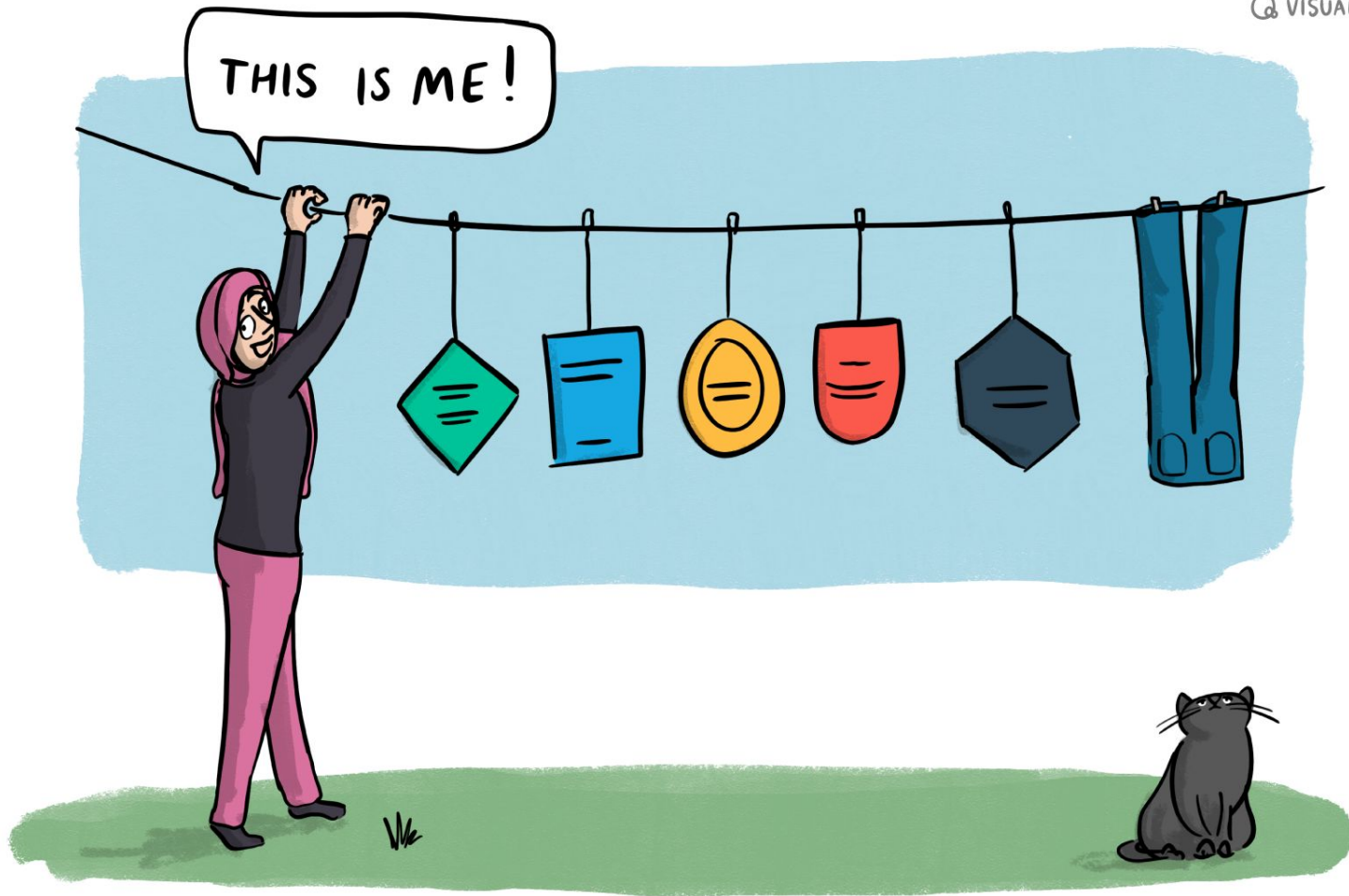
TERRITORIES



TO APPLY THEIR OWN LABELS & DEFINITIONS...



SO TELL ME,
HOW DID YOU
GET HERE?



“

I love this project because it provides clear and immediate value by quickly connecting individuals to job opportunities.



(Kymberly Lavigne-Hinkley, Director, Learning and Employment Record Ecosystem, Western Governors University)

”

Slides: <https://bit.ly/epic-new-americans>

Thanks for listening!

If you'd like to follow-up on any of this, just catch us while we're here, or email:

doug@weareopen.coop

julie.keane@participate.com

